

favourite channels in the bouquet, but this will change. Meanwhile, Oberai proclaims, "IPTV is changing the Internet!"

Be it IPTV or the alternatives, we will need fatter pipes.

The 2 Mbps Revolution (?)

When Dayanidhi Maran, Union Minister of Telecommunications and IT, announced that we'll see speeds of up to 2 Mbps on our existing MTNL and BSNL connections, we took it with a pinch of salt. We Indians aren't used to prompt action, are we? And yet, amidst much fanfare, we entered the New Year with, sure enough, 2 Mbps connections.

Barely a few days after that, You Telecom announced their 2 Mbps plans; as of this writing, Airtel and You Telecom are the only ones who offer such speeds to the home user. "In his announcement, Mr Maran encouraged private providers to match MTNL's upcoming offers, so we did," says Chakravarthy simply.

Airtel announced its 2 Mbps plans nearly a month later—why the delay? "We were preparing to provide higher speeds—I believe everyone was. You Telecom did trump us, but we'll see 2 Mbps plans from everyone soon enough," says Endlaw.

But is the 2 Mbps picture all peachy? The first thing that hits you when you visit the providers' sites is that there still isn't an affordable 2 Mbps plan with unlimited data transfer. The second thing is that transfer limits haven't been changed; considering that you'll hit that limit much faster with the 2 Mbps connection, you'll need to watch your usage very carefully, or face the bill shocks that hit people when they got too carried away with their first month of a 2 Mbps connection. "2 Mbps could lose credibility this way," says Chakravarthy, "Tomorrow, if you've been burned by the bills, you'll tell your friends not to fall for it, they'll tell their friends, and so on."

Sify, on the other hand, won't be going the 2 Mbps way soon. "It's all hype," says Ajwani. "There will be a lot of complaints with the download limits. 85 per cent of Internet users go online for e-mail and Instant Messaging—do they



Just as it's our responsibility to provide our customers with the best speeds and service, it's their responsibility to keep us alive by paying a fair price"

E. V. S. Chakravarthy
CEO, You Telecom

even need 2 Mbps?"

You're probably appalled at this statement, but this is the truth in the Indian "hybrid market," as Ajwani puts it. The disparity between the geek's demands and the average user's is tremendous, and for now, the majority—meaning the average user—is going to drive the plans available in India. Did you know that a lot of people don't even hit their download limits?

So while urban users scream themselves hoarse for faster, unlimited connections, others scream themselves hoarse just for connections, period.

But we digress. It's early days yet for the 2 Mbps brigade—both MTNL and BSNL warn that it depends on the line condition. If you're closer to the telephone exchange and the lines in your area are being maintained properly, you'll see the speeds. If not, you'll find yourself at the receiving end of a broken promise. Feedback is online for all to view—you'll find it on any Indian technology forum, including our own; the disparity is mind-boggling. As is the disparity in the quality of service...

Meat, And Poison

You're quite happy with your ISP—good prices, speeds as advertised, and decent customer support. You recommend it to your friend in another area of the city. Ten days later, you get showered with abuses for your recommendation. What happened?

There are two facets to service—firstly, who's providing it, and secondly, how much bandwidth has been allocated to the area in question. When an ISP provides its service through a franchisee—usually a local cable operator—you're bound to see differences in the quality of service across areas. Sify has been dealing with this for a long time. On the other hand, Endlaw assures, "We manage our own customer service, so barring minor differences, you'll see consistent quality across the country."

The second aspect is bandwidth management—if there are 200 subscribers for 256 Kbps connections in an area that has only 30 Mbps allocated to it, there are naturally going to be problems.

Then there's the matter of the customer himself being wrong. Even something as silly as someone tripping over and dislodging the network cable becomes an irate "My Internet isn't working!" call to the service centre.

On paper, You Telecom's plan is the best we've heard so far. Unless the problem with your connection is physical—a broken wire, a faulty network switch, and so on—you'll still be able to connect to their service site, where you will be asked for a 10-digit code. Once you do so, your system is analysed (with your permission, of course) to ensure that everything is all right at your end—no viruses, proper settings, etc. If all is well, someone will come over to service the connection, and soon after the technician leaves, you'll receive a text message asking you for feedback on the quality of service you received. Your reply to that message will enable them to give you better service in the future...on paper.

Choosing A Broadband Connection

Use the Web sites as only an indication—do your groundwork before you settle on an ISP.

- ❑ Check with people in your area. Despite the official word, the quality of service *does* vary from region to region, and to different degrees. Make sure you speak to your neighbours about the ISP they're using and the quality of service.
- ❑ Be very careful when signing up with an operator who's just started offering services. All will be peachy in the beginning, but there's a good chance that the service may degrade as more subscribers come on board. Where possible, opt for someone established—you'll get consistent service, as any kinks in the infrastructure will have been ironed out.
- ❑ If you're opting for an MTNL or BSNL connection, find out when the neighbourhood infrastructure was last upgraded, especially if you're far from the telephone exchange—the quality of the wiring and the distance from the exchange will determine your speeds.